

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Collaboration, the key
Bharatham festival: When dancers and musicians find a common ground **p2**

The making of Kumar Gandharv
Scholar and musician Srijan Deshpande chronicles the life and music of the maestro **p3**



ODE TO THE QUEEN OF COUNTRY MUSIC

Looking at the humane side of the singer who passed away recently **p4**

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Sanskrit and algorithms? They seem worlds apart, yet the ancient language has emerged as an unlikely point of interest for researches in artificial intelligence. Its precise, rule-bound grammar is drawing the attention of scientists and technologists exploring machine translation, computational linguistics, and natural language processing.

Sanskrit's framework is so algorithmic that a 1985 NASA paper cited it as a model for machine language. But the connection between Sanskrit and science is far older. It can be traced back 2,500 years to Shalatlula (present-day Pakistan), when Panini composed the Ashtadhyayi – 4,000 rules that transformed language into logic.

Far from being confined to scriptures and temple rituals, Sanskrit is reinventing itself in the most unlikely ways by making its way into rap, adventure rides and instagram content.

While earlier pioneers have experimented with Sanskrit on screen and stage, today, Gen Z is driving the language's revival through technology and their distinct creativity. They are reshaping the language's image, infusing it into reels, raps and adventure activities. For instance, Bengaluru-based Kimbho Sanskrit Riders Club hits the road with the sole purpose of popularising Sanskrit. Its members aspire to make it an everyday language, beyond classrooms or rituals.

"Members meet every alternate weekend at Cubbon Park and set off on monthly rides to temples, cruises in Goa, bungee-jumping venues and even casinos, all while conversing in Sanskrit and teaching newcomers its basics. The idea is to normalise Sanskrit by using it in everyday settings," says Samashti Gubbi, who started the club in 2024.

"The name 'Kimbho' itself reflects this casual spirit: it loosely translates to 'what's up?' – a Sanskrit equivalent of local lingos such as 'en guru' or 'en samachara' in Kannada," she explains.

At Cubbon Park, Kimbho's gatherings include Nature walks and interactive activities – from introductions to learning verbs, numbers and sentence structures. With members mostly in the 20-40 age group, the sessions are free, while participants fund their own trips.

The club's ambitious vision extends beyond outreach. It aims to create a platform where Sanskrit learners become actors, writers, singers and filmmakers. "Kimbho is currently working on a Sanskrit film titled *Mitram*, a contemporary story," shares Samashti.

Sanskrit is finding new traction on Instagram reels and other social media platforms, where it merges with rhythms, rhymes, and beats. Tribe Sanskrit, founded by Hridya



Suresh from Coimbatore and Vinamra Herle from Mangaluru, promotes Sanskrit through raps and reels. The Sanskrit graduates, from Chinmaya Vishwavidyapeeth, Ernakulam, post reels of popular songs in Sanskrit – from the Malayalam hit *Kaanta* to the soulful *Chaudhary*. Their version of *Chaudhary* even caught the attention of the original singer, Mame Khan, who shared it with words of appreciation. They are also experimenting with Sanskrit rap, adapting contemporary tracks such as *Dhurandhar* title song, besides singing the birthday song and

creating New Year greetings.

"We believe the youth today is keen to reconnect with its roots, and Sanskrit helps them to do that. We want to make the language relatable," says Hridya. They carry the same energy offline too, conducting workshops and teaching the language in schools and colleges.

Their journey underscores how Sanskrit is being reclaimed by the youth, not just as a relic, but as a vibrant medium of artistic



Bridging worlds (Clockwise from left) Kimbho riders taking off on the road, making the language cool with camping and adventures, and Sanskrit Tribe rappers. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



expression and recreation.

The credit for keeping the language alive also goes to earlier generations of Sanskrit lovers. Institutions such as Chennai's Sanskrit College – founded in 1906 – have sustained the language's academic tradition by training enthusiasts. Filmmakers have also played a significant role in expanding its reach. Among them was G.V. Iyer, who won rave reviews for his Sanskrit film *Adi Shankaracharya*. In recent times director and theatre practitioner, K. Suchendra Prasad has directed three Sanskrit films – *Prapaatha*, *Ekachakram*, and *Padmagandhi* – proving that Sanskrit continues to thrive on screen and stage.

Suchendra even went on a year-long tour with his latest play, *Pitamaha*, a theatrical adaptation of

Nanna Pitamaha, a Kannada literary work by Veena Bannanje, which celebrates Padumunnuru Narayanachaarya, father of scholar Bannanje Govindachaarya, and their contributions to Sanskrit.

The language of the play is a reminder of how deeply Sanskrit permeates India's linguistic fabric, with most Indian languages drawing heavily on its vocabulary and structure.

"Theatre must communicate reality, not distort facts and history," Suchendra believes. His year-long staging of *Pitamaha* culminated in a performance at Bengaluru's Gayana Samaja earlier this month. For Suchendra, the play was "not just theatre but also a tribute to the many unspoken literary giants, and documenting their legacy."

Suchendra carries the same conviction in his films. While *Prapaatha* is based on sage Bharadwaja's *Vaimaanika Shaastra*, *Padmagandhi* revolves around the lotus flower and its medicinal values. "*Prapaatha* ignited curiosity and has been screened several times at institutions such as ISRO and IISc, often sparking lengthy debates." For him, Sanskrit is "a scientific, creative medium".

Not just in India, Sanskrit's presence is visible across Asia – from Thailand's temples, and Indonesia's literary traditions to Cambodia's Khmer culture. It's influence is also felt in the most unexpected places such as Pakistan. In 2025, actor Alyy Khan, known for his work in Bollywood and Hollywood, surprised audiences during an interview. When complimented for his felicity in Hindi, he switched to Sanskrit and recited the 'Saraswati Vandana', even explaining its meaning in English. Shahid Rasheed, associate professor of sociology at Forman Christian College in Lahore, took up the study of Sanskrit and later helped launched a Sanskrit course at the Lahore University of Management Sciences. The professor sees Sanskrit as a cultural monument that binds the region together.

With a legacy that spans several centuries Sanskrit continues to evolve and remain relevant.

CULTUREBRIEFS

Chakravyuh on stage



Agratrade, in association with KRR Air presents *Chakravyuh* on August 29, 6.15 p.m., at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall, Harrington Road. Nitish Bharadwaj, known for his portrayal of Krishna in the popular television series *Mahabharath*, reprises the role in this stage production. Written and directed by Atul Satya Koushik, *Chakravyuh* has been staged for over a decade, making it one of the longest-running productions in Indian theatre. The play depicts events from the 13th day of the Mahabharata war and examines leadership, strategy, ethics, and decision-making. Part of the proceeds will go towards educational scholarships and social empowerment programmes.

Reimagining Madhavi's story



merely a secondary character in Kovalan and Kannagi's story. It combines movement, music, poetry, acting and narration to present the unknown side of Madhavi. The production is backed by recorded music featuring well-known musicians S. Sowmya, Haricharan, Palghat Sreeram, Pradeep Kumar, Saindhavi and Punya Srinivas. Tickets on kyn.

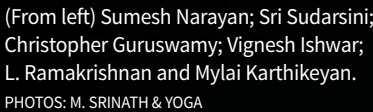
Ranga Mandira presents *Nammai Marandarai Naam Marakkamaattom*, a dance-theatre production conceived and choreographed by Swarnamalya Ganesh, on August 30, 6.30 p.m., at Narada Gana Sabha. The production focuses on Madhavi, the accomplished dancer from Ilango Adigal's timeless Tamil epic *Silappadikaram*, rather than

Seamless synergy

The 2026 edition of the tree-day Smriti festival will be inaugurated today at Rukmini Arangam, Kalakshetra. It brings together well-known Kathak and Bharatanatyam artistes including Padma Subrahmanyam, Chitra Visweswaran, Pt. Rajendra Gangani, Saswati Sen, Nandkishore Kapote, Malti Shyam and Vishal Krishna. It will also feature young performers.

On the occasion, 'Smriti Yuva Puraskar', instituted in memory of Pt. Birju Maharaj, will be presented to Kathak dancer Vishal Krishna, and veteran Bharatanatyam dancer-guru Chitra Visweswaran will also be felicitated for her contribution to the field of dance.





The formidable team of musicians played a crucial role. Sri Sudarsini's nattuvangam remained firmly in control, while her rendition of jathis was appealing. Sumesh Narayan seamlessly integrated the mridangam and kanjira rhythms into the soundscape. The use of nagaswaram at pertinent points, enriched the narrative without overpowering the ensemble. L. Ramakrishnan's brilliant violin playing blended beautifully with the orchestra. Vignesh Ishwar's robust voice and sensitive singing complemented the performance.

From the gentle touch of vayu, the narrative shifted to its destructive power and the havoc it can unleash. This was depicted with vigour in 'Katre vaa meduva

In a thematic presentation, balancing nritya and abhinaya can be challenging, as the nritya must showcase the dancer's skills without disrupting the flow

The music was composed by Gayathri Girish, who also sang the compositions. Jathis were composed by Guru Bharadwaaj, who played the mridangam. Nattuvangam was by Sri Sudarsini, with violin by T.V. Sukanya, flute by R.S. Adhwaith and percussion by K.S. Ramana. The ensemble created a rich and responsive soundscape through vocals, percussion, chanting, narration, musical effects and nattuvangam. In her first collaboration with a Bharatanatyam dancer, Gayathri adapted well to the demands of the form, providing strong yet sensitive musical support.

Harinie Jeevitha (Top); Gayathri Girish, Sri Sudarsini, T.V. Sukanya, R.S. Adhvaith and K.S. Ramana lent strong musical support. PHOTOS: M. SRINATH AND YOGA

Harshita Vidya, who replaced vocalist Ashwarya Vidya Raghunath, at the last minute, did a commendable job. However, there were moments when she could have enhanced the impact with a more energetic rendition. T.S. Sharath conducted the recital with Vinod Shyam Anoor (mridangam and kanjira) and Rakshita Ramesh (veena). Keerthi Kumar's lighting design enhanced the visual appeal of the performance.

Devina Dutt

There are excellent musicians, and then there are the prodigious and multifarious ones who leave successive generations of artistes, scholars and listeners with something to ponder for decades after they have passed. In the world of Hindustani music, nobody embodies this more completely than Pt. Kumar Gandharva.

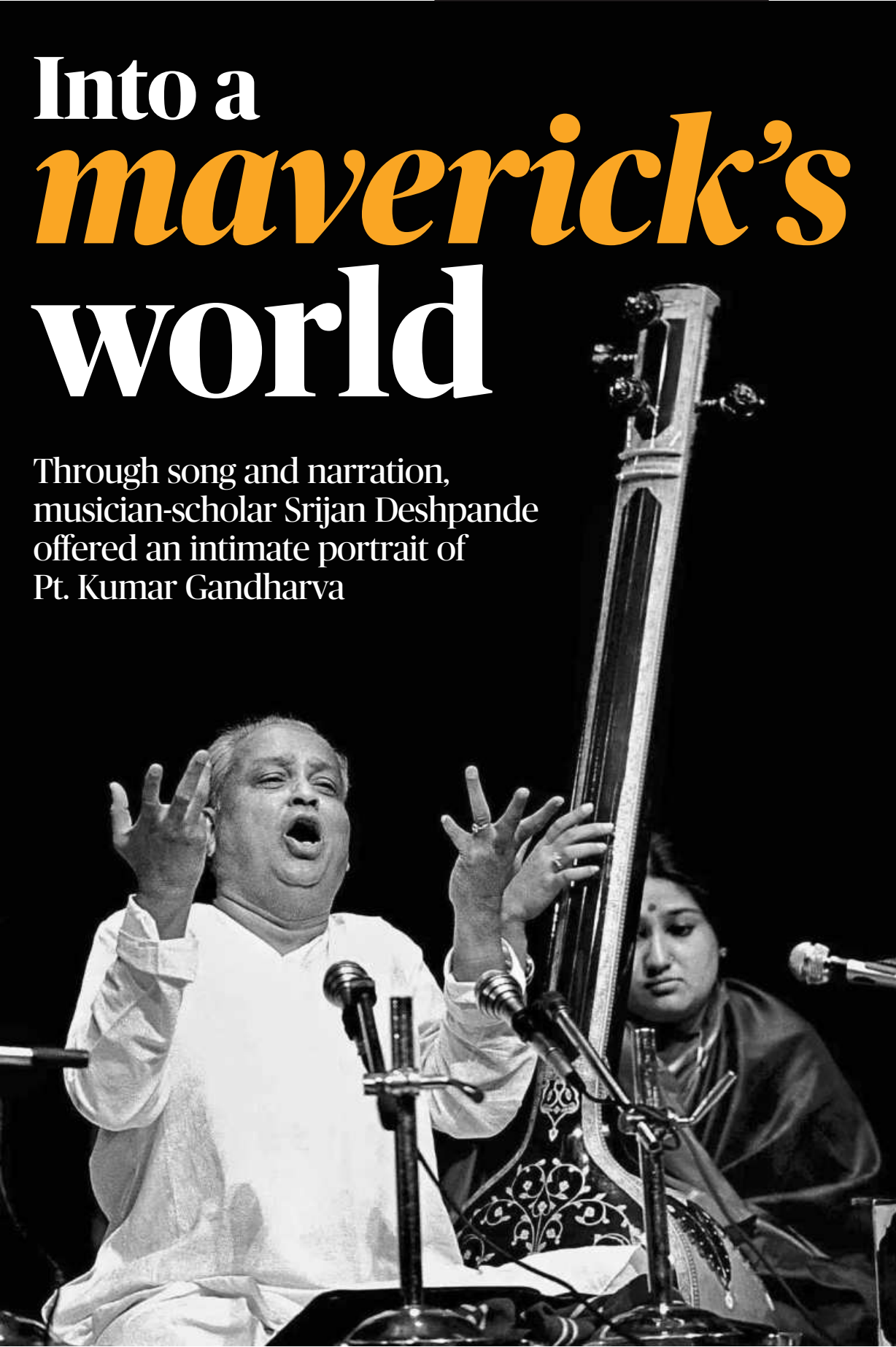
Scholar, archivist, Hindustani musician and teacher Srijan Deshpande recently presented an unusual but deeply engaging conversation-cum-concert, *The Stories and Songs of Kumar Gandharva*. Srijan shared key moments from the legendary musician's journey as a composer, focussing on a particularly eventful 15-year period of his short but creatively charged life.

Untypically for a Hindustani classical programme, there was, to use one of Kumar ji's favourite words, a *svabhavik* or natural flow to the concert set in the intimacy of the library at the Bangalore International Centre.

Spanning the years between his triumphant return to singing in 1952 after battling TB and the publication of his first anthology of original compositions, *Anuprag Vilas*, in 1965, the evening was a rare exception to the Hindustani concert template. Hindustani musicians have rarely cared to explain or share their thoughts on the creative process and their artistic journeys. But Kumar ji was an unusually expressive artiste, given to long periods of creative ferment, who believed it was his duty to connect with his listeners intellectually as well as artistically.

As the conversation and music presented in short bursts of passionate singing by Srijan, animated moments from Pt. Kumar Gandharva's life, we realised that this was a musician who saw no conflict between the mundane and the artistic. Further, he could experience and internalise the music devoid of any notion of hierarchy or an overblown sense of himself as a classical musician.

Able to encounter the world as it came to him, Pt. Kumar Gandharva



Into a maverick's world

Through song and narration, musician-scholar Srijan Deshpande offered an intimate portrait of Pt. Kumar Gandharva

► **Making of a maestro** Pt. Kumar Gandharva and (below) Srijan Deshpande. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Srijan, a disciple of his father, the noted Hindustani musician and musicologist Satyasheel Deshpande, who in turn trained under Pt. Kumar Gandharva, has been working on a book on the maestro, scheduled for publication next year.

was a Hindustani musician who could be captivated by the smallest of things and find in them the material for new compositions. For instance, he was charmed by the musically resonant names of villages Dewas, such as Amona and Binjana, whose very names set him off on song-making replete with wordplay and melody.

Doubtless, this creative outpouring was linked to those five years of enforced silence he spent recuperating from TB. It was the folk tunes of villagers passing by his home and the sweetness of the Malwi dialect that set a new set of slow-burning musical ideas into motion. He heard songs sung throughout the day as villagers went about their chores. There were songs on the seasons, the cycles of farming activity and the famous *barahmasa* tradition, in which a single tune was sung for every month of the local calendar.

Srijan makes a compelling

raconteur, employing insight, scholarship, empathy and humour to take us through the many transformations and new directions Kumar ji pursued even as he remained too ill to sing between 1947 and 1952. Nursed by his first wife, Bhanumati, during this difficult time, he composed a bandish when she one day broke down in tears. It was a Patmanjari that carried grief within its ingenious weave of five conjoined raags, Kumar ji writes:

Sajal naina kaahé? gori kaaran bataade ri! naa hum dekh sakat toraa shok, naa shobhe dragjal tohe, gori kaaran bataade ri! (why do your eyes fill up with tears?, fair one, tell me why! I cannot bear to see your grief, tears do not beseech you, fair one, tell me why!)

Srijan compared the composition to a weave, as raags such as Maru Bihag, Nand, Bhinna Shadja, Kedar and Shankara meet, intersect and overlap to “give rise to something new, something whole, something that is as much a simple dhun as it is a brilliant conjoining of five heavyweight raags.”

When Pt. Kumar Gandharva returned to Mumbai in 1952, his fresh and distinctive *gayaki* filled many with wonder. Srijan points out that the Marathi humourist and writer P.L. Deshpande likened him to a *mahapurush* who had emerged to breathe new life into the stagnant waters of Hindustani music, adding that the eminent actor Dr. Shreeram Lagoo refused to listen to anyone else.

For the past several years, Srijan, a disciple of his father, the noted Hindustani musician and musicologist Satyasheel Deshpande, who in turn trained under Pt. Kumar Gandharva, has been working on a book on the maestro, scheduled for publication next year.

This was a deeply resonant journey through history, geography and biography, moving from Pune and the Deodhar School of Music in Mumbai to the quiet hills of Dewas. Along the way, it was enriched by insightful exchanges among musicians and scholars, including Kumar Gandharva's guru B.R. Deodhar, as well as Wamanrao Deshpande and Vasant Rao Deshpande.

Beats from the Backwaters

Sri Sashta Kshetra Vadya Sangam has kept the Chenda tradition alive in Chennai through free coaching



Manasa Vijayalakshme C

Even as the echoes of Onam fade, the thunderous rhythms of Chenda Melam linger, evoking the vibrant sounds of Kerala's temple festivals. In Chennai, Sri Sashta Kshetra Vadya Sangam, Villivakkam, has been keeping the tradition alive and accessible through free Chenda classes that attract learners across generations.

The institution was founded by Rajeev Kumar, whose association with the temple began in his childhood. His father, C.N. Sukumaran Guruswamy, founded the Villivakkam Ayyappan Temple. The idea for the institution emerged during preparations for the temple's second kumbabishekam in 2013, when Rajeev's father expressed a desire to have an in-house Chenda troupe, as bringing teams from Kerala was expensive. Inspired by the idea, Rajeev decided to learn the Chenda. He trained under guru Devaraj Marar for two years.

Though Rajeev was fortunate to have found a guru in the city, the experience made him realise how difficult it was for aspiring Chenda players in Chennai to receive a formal training. “Not everyone can afford to travel to Kerala and stay there to learn. “That bothered me, and I decided to start an institution,” says Rajeev.

Rajeev, under the guidance of his father, established Sri Sashta Kshetra Vadya Sangam as a charitable trust with a simple objective: make Chenda Melam accessible to anyone interested in learning it, regardless

of gender or language. Rajeev teaches in Tamil, English and Malayalam, and says offering free classes remains integral to the institution's purpose.

New students begin with Chembada Talam, which Rajeev describes as a basic form. Then, they progress to Panchaari Melam and Adantha Melam. Rajeev says learning the basics takes around four to five months. An arangetram is held for the students every December. The institution is preparing for its 10th batch in 2026 and has so far had nearly 150 students.

The learners include young boys and girls, and even middle-aged men and women. Shankar A. and R. Karthick conduct the Chenda classes.

For Shankar, teaching involves breaking the course into smaller sections so students can understand and practise each part before putting them together. Regular practice, he adds, helps improve concentration and makes lessons easier to learn.

Rhythm is central to Chenda Melam. Rajeev explains that its rhythmic structure is similar to that of Carnatic percussion, though the presentation differs. The performance incorporates a range of talas, including Chembada, Adantha and Panchaari, each contributing to its distinctive sound.

Chenda Melam brings together a range of instruments, including the chenda, ezhathalam, kombu, idakka and kuzhal, with diverse talas and rhythmic patterns forming its musical framework. The institution's

efforts, says Rajeev, have been sustained by the positive response from both students and parents. “Once the training is completed, we take our students to perform at festivals and events across Chennai,” he adds.

Younger learners say they were first drawn to the instrument's powerful sound. Ten-year-old T. Nikhil, who has already completed his arangetram, recalls being fascinated with the chenda when he saw it being played at the temple. “I now enjoy playing it,” he says.

► **Rhythm reverie** Students during the rehearsal for the Onam performance, which was presented in Chennai on August 26. PHOTOS: J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

Eight-year-old Jeevitesh shares a similar story.

The institution has also given women an opportunity to learn an art form that was not always accessible to them. Says 49-year-old Sini Sreekrishnan, “I wanted to learn it since childhood. Whenever I pick up the instrument and play, I am transported to Kerala.” She also appreciates the inclusive environment at the Sangam. “There is no discrimination on the basis of gender or age here.”

Sri Sashta Kshetra Vadya Sangam in Villivakkam offers a reminder that Kerala's musical traditions can thrive well beyond the State's borders. By creating opportunities for people of all ages and backgrounds to learn and perform, it is ensuring that the resonant rhythms of Chenda Melam continue to find new audiences and practitioners.

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Sri Jayanti festival

- **Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha** will present the 15th year Sri Jayanthi music festival from August 30 to September 13 at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar. On the occasion, the 'Vani Kala Nipuna' title will be presented to Sunil R. Gargyan (vocal), Charumathi Raghuraman (violin), Vijay B. Natesan (mridangam), Thiruveezhimizhalai Kanaka Krishna Prashanth (Bharatanatyam) and Karthik Bhatt (theatre). Namasankirtanam (4.30 p.m.) and music concerts (6.30 p.m.) will form part of the festival. The inaugural concert will be by Mambalam sisters (7 p.m.).
- **At ISKCON** Chennai, a series of special programmes will be held on September 4, from 4.30 a.m. Srimad Bhagavatam class (7.15 a.m.), guru puja (8 a.m.), and rendition of kirtans (10 a.m.), culminating in maha abishekam at 12.30 p.m. form part of the line up. Vyasa puja, dedicated to the founder Swami Srila Prabhupada, will be performed on September 5, from 4.30 a.m. to 12.30 p.m.

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Queen of Country



► **Ode to an icon**
(Clockwise from left)
Dolly Parton at
Glastonbury music
festival on June 29,
2014; with former U.S.
President Jimmy
Carter and first lady
Rosalynn Carter at a
luncheon for country
music entertainers at
the White House on
October 2, 1979; and
with Wagon Masters
singing for a Civic
Center Music Hall
audience in Oklahoma
City on October 8,
1968. PHOTOS: AP & RON
HILL VIA REUTERS



Dolly Parton , who passed away recently, gave away more than 300 million books and millions of dollars in aid, but refused to surrender the copyright to one song, even for Elvis Presley.



through Sevier County in November 2016, killing 14 people and destroying more than a thousand homes, her foundation had the My People Fund running within 48 hours. Around 900 families received \$1,000 a month for six months, with a final payment of \$5,000, so every household got \$10,000 in cash. Nobody was means-tested and nobody had to explain how the money was spent.

In April 2020 she gave \$1 million to Vanderbilt University Medical Center, which paid for the early stage of the research behind the Moderna vaccine. The following March she filmed herself taking the shot and sang ‘vaccine, vaccine, vaccine, vaccine’ to the tune of her own chorus. Last November, the Academy presented her with the Jean Hersholt Humanitarian Award, an honorary Oscar recognising outstanding humanitarian efforts.

Her nephew Bryan Seaver announced the death in a video she had asked him to record in advance, which is a very Dolly Parton way of handling the one thing she could not control. He said she had farmed songs and happiness the way her father farmed soil. She had told him she wanted to rest in a beautiful bed of plush cotton after a lifetime of heavy rhinestones. The grief this week has come from country singers and drag queens, from presidents of both parties, from people who own every record and from people who only ever knew one. That is a strange crowd to hold together. She managed it for 60 years without once pretending to be something she was not.

That stage is still waiting for her. *DOLLY: A True Original Musical*, with a book she co-wrote and new songs she wrote for it, begins previews at the St. James Theatre on December 7 and opens on January 19, 2027.

She would have been 81 that day.

Rachel Rhine

In 1974, the night before Elvis Presley was due in the studio to record ‘I Will Always Love You’, Dolly Parton’s phone rang. Colonel Tom Parker, Presley’s manager, had a condition nobody had mentioned earlier. Elvis would record the song only if Parker’s side received half the publishing rights to it.

Parton was 28. She had just walked away from the television show that made her a household name in America, with no guarantee that a solo career would succeed. The biggest star in the world wanted her song. She said no and, by her own account, cried all night.

Eighteen years later, Whitney Houston recorded ‘I will always love you’ for the opening sequence of *The Bodyguard*, turning it into one of the best-selling singles. Because Parton had refused to give up any

share of the song’s publishing rights, she received the royalties from its enormous success. She later joked that turning Elvis down had earned her enough money to buy Graceland.

She told that story for decades, always with a laugh, and how it held the shape of her whole life inside it. Parton, the ‘Queen of Country Music’, died on August 25 at the Vanderbilt-Ingram Cancer Center in Nashville with her family around her. She was 80. Her publicist said she had faced a brief battle with cancer.

Dolly Parton was born on January 19, 1946, in a one-room cabin in Sevier County, in the East Tennessee mountains, the fourth of 12 children. Her father, Robert Lee Parton, was a sharecropper who could not read or write. Her mother sang the old ballads that had come over from the British Isles.

Parton sang on local radio at 10, appeared at the Grand Ole Opry at 13, and left for Nashville in

1964, the morning after she finished high school.

Porter Wagoner brought her onto his television show in September 1967, when she was 21. In *Star of the Show*, the memoir she published last year, she wrote that the salary of \$60,000 a year felt like a million dollars to a girl from Locust Ridge. She stayed seven years and never got a raise. Wagoner gave her jewellery and a Cadillac instead and told her to consider the gifts her raise. She wanted the money.

So she wrote her way out. ‘I will always love you’ was a goodbye letter to him, and she sang it in his office before she played it for anyone else. He cried, then asked to produce the record. ‘Jolene’ came out of the same run of writing, and both songs are still being picked up half a century on. ‘Pentatonix’ won her a Grammy with an a cappella ‘Jolene’ in 2017. Beyoncé rewrote it for *Cowboy Carter* in 2024, with Parton voicing an

interlude on the album.

She wrote close to 3,000 songs, put 25 singles at the top of Billboard’s country chart, and sold more than 100 million records. Ten Grammys came from 55 nominations, which left her the third most-nominated woman in the award’s history. The Country Music Hall of Fame took her in 1999, the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame in 2022.

For someone so careful about what she kept, she gave away an enormous amount.

In 1995 she started the Imagination Library, which posts a free book every month to any child under five who is signed up. She began it for her father, who could not read but whom she called the smartest man she knew. It runs in five countries, sends out more than three million books a month, and has given away over 300 million. One in six American children under the age of five is enrolled.

When wildfires tore



► **Pristine**
Francesca
Khalifa
performed
recently at the
Bangalore
International
Centre.
PHOTO COURTESY:
ARTISTE’S WEBSITE

Key notes

Pianist Francesca Khalifa brings Bach and Haydn to life at her concert

Malini White

Italian-Egyptian pianist Francesca Khalifa performed for Bangalore’s International Music & Arts Society at Bangalore International Centre recently. It was a welcome offering after a fairly long period without any concerts. Francesca raised exotic expectations, though her appearance turned out to be normal southern European – with a number of striking tattoos!

A co-founder and artistic director of EXTENSITY Concert Series, that aims at “the disruption of gender, racial and cultural inequity in the classical music world”, Francesca has not found herself excluded because of her mixed background.

Two Bach pieces were an unusual opening for a recital. Bach is heard less frequently on the concert platform because performers often doubt whether the transcribed versions can successfully evoke the essential quality of the original work. Francesca had thought carefully about how best to convey the harpsichord’s limited range on the more mellow temperament of the modern piano: “Does one use the pedal, for example, which the harpsichord did not have?” (Francesca, notably, did not pedal for either of the Bach pieces). Bach is also not a recital favourite as “... memorising him is difficult because almost all of his writing is polyphonal, in lateral layers”.

The *Bach-Busoni cantata, Wachet auf, ruft uns die Stimme BWV 104/II* is best known for its famous hymn, the beautiful ‘Sleepers Awake’. Busoni allows Bach’s reverent writing to resonate in its rich melodic and rhythmic phrases, while rendering the majestic key of B flat with reserve and restraint, to retain the original spiritual and emotional impact of what Alfred Dürr called ‘Christian mysticism’.

In the Bach *Partita #1* in B flat *BVW 825*, the complicated polyphony spoke clearly, the tempi and register capturing the characteristic counterpoint. In both Bach pieces, Francesca’s touch was light but sure, imbuing both with delicacy and tenderness.

Her effortlessness did not betray the difficulty of the piece, a *tour de force* of keyboard

technique, unparalleled in Bach’s day: for example, the whole right hand continually jumping over the left. A critic of the time, Mizler, observed, “He who cannot move his fingers ... will scarcely be able to learn to play ... the elegant flourishes and ornaments of the Partitas.”

In fact, the whole programme was notable for high technical quality of the keyboard method which Francesca rendered effortlessly, instead of being purposefully apparent – always the hallmark of great artistry, making the difficult look easy!

Unfortunately, the thin, almost tinny sound quality of the piano deprived the second half of the programme of its rightful beauty. Where was the sonorous impact of *Haydn’s Sonata XVI/20L33 in C*, described as ‘Haydn’s Appassionata’? The Sonata, marked for its harmony, symmetry and *Strum und Drang* dynamics, needed a rich sound quality, which even judicious use of the forte pedal could not produce. (Francesca’s voluminous trousers obscured her feet, but one could hear her use of the pedals].

Her effortlessness did not betray the difficulty of the piece, a tour de force of keyboard technique, unparalleled in Bach’s day: for example, the whole right hand continually jumping over the left.

The emotional yearning of the lovely *Schumann Op. 17 Fantasy* was masterfully captured, though again, the instrument was not equal to its raw passion, from deep, introspective, quieter moments to the *langsam’s* tonal beauty.

Unfortunately, the slated *Saint-Saens/Liszt Danse Macabre* had to be cancelled, with Francesca finding the available instrument unequal to the piece’s demands. – another that commands phenomenal technique, with Liszt at his diabolical best.

As an encore she chose to repeat the *Andante* of the *Haydn Sonata*.

A pity that the piano’s quality could not do justice to this musician’s keyboard mastery, leaving the evening with a feeling of disappointment.

CALENDAR

Dance of divinity

Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra (SBKK) presents the 50th show of its dance drama ‘Krishna’ from August 29 to September 4, at Kamani Auditorium, New Delhi. Time: 3.30 p.m. and 6.30 p.m. The production, staged every Janmashtami season, is conceptualised by Sumitra Charat Ram, directed by Shobha Deepak Singh (chairman, SBKK) and choreographed by Shashidharan Nair, with support from Raj Kumar Sharma. It traces Krishna’s journey from Gokul to Vrindavan, his bond with Radha and the defeat of Kansa to his role in the Mahabharata and his dialogue with Arjuna at Kurukshetra. The drama culminates with Bhagavad Gita’s message of peace and responsible action. ‘Krishna’ today employs LED screens and digital backdrops, alongside handcrafted costumes, jewellery, special sets and light design. The score draws largely on bhakti compositions, with lyrics from Surdas’s Sur-Sagar sung in the original Brij bhasha.



Tickets available on BookMyShow.

Music festival

Narada Gana Sabha Trust presents the 39th Sri Sadguru Gnanananda Sangeetha Sammelan for four days from September 1 at its mini hall. A series of concerts by well-known musicians will form part of the festival. Artists to perform on the occasion are: September 1, 3 p.m.: Kalakad R. Thyagrajan and Kalakad R. Srinivasan; 4.30 p.m.: Savitha Sreeram; 6 p.m.: Senkottai Hari Hara Subramaniam and 7.30 p.m.: Nagai R. Muralidharan and G. Badrinarayanan (violin). September 2, 3 p.m.: Varalakshmi Anandakumar and Kanaka Durga Venkatesh (vocal duet); 4.30 p.m.: Sikkil C. Gurucharan; 6 p.m.: Sikkil Mala Chandrasekar (flute) and 7.30 p.m.: Srimushnam V. Raja Rao and Senkottai Hari Hara Subramaniam (vocal duet). September 3, 3 p.m.: B. Suchitra; 4.30 p.m.: A. Kanyakumari and Embar Kannan (violin duet); 6 p.m.: Kannan Balakrishnan (Madura Veena) and 7.30 p.m.: Kunnakudi M. Balamurali Krishna. September 4, 3 p.m.: Gayathri Girish and 4.30 p.m.: S. Mahathi; 6.15 p.m.: sadas and 7.30 p.m.: Hari and Giri Bhagavatar (namasankirtanam).

HCL concert

The Music Academy will feature Shambhavi Jagadish’s Bharatanatyam performance as part of HCL Concerts, today, 6 p.m., at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

Talk on Bhakti yoga

Chinmaya Mission and Sringeri Bharathi Vidyashram presents Geeta Gyana Yagna, a series of talks, in Tamil, by Swami Sivayogananda, Chinmaya Mission, Madurai, till August 30. Titled ‘Devotion to Divinity’ it is taking place at Sringeri Bharathi Vidyashram, T. Nagar. Time: 6.45 p.m.

Tamil play

Narada Gana Sabha presents Natakakavalara Chemmal R.S.Manohar’s NXGS’ *Lankeshwaran* today at 6.30 p.m. and Mother Creations’ *Jagadguru*, on August 29, 6.30 p.m.: Venue: Sathguru Gnanananda Hall.

